Narooma Branch

Contact Details

22 September 2025

The Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters

Dear Joint Standing Committee

This submission to the Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters inquiry into the conduct of the 2025 federal election and related matters is made on behalf of the Narooma Branch of the

Our responses to the Terms of Reference for the inquiry are:

- **Assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers, and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials.**

  In previous election pre-polling periods, there would be between 2-3 volunteers at any one time from the Narooma branches of the and the Party) and 1-2 volunteers for minor parties. All volunteers were generally polite and respectful, giving every party the opportunity to engage with voters when they wished to do so.

  The number of volunteers during the pre-polling period and the 3 May 2025 polling day was vastly different to previous federal and state elections, with between 9 and 12 at any one time. These numbers were also disproportionate to the number of Narooma members giving rise to concerns of attempted electoral interference by volunteers from outside our community and electorate.

  It is the Narooma Branch's understanding that the engagement of a significant third party, the Plymouth Brethren, to provide large numbers of volunteers for pre-polling and polling day to, in effect, flood the zone with a presence and occupy the space required by other candidates' campaign material and volunteers. Some of these Brethren volunteers also disclosed to other candidates' supporters that they were being paid to participate in this process.

  During the pre-polling period and polling day Narooma Branch members and volunteers:
  1. usurped space in front of pre-polling and polling booths;
  2. prevented other candidates from being able to display campaign material in the designated area;
  3. stood in front of other candidates' volunteers to inhibit their ability to engage with voters;
  4. made clearly false statements to voters;
  5. clustered around, often older, voters in a manner that bordered on intimidatory;
  6. followed voters up the ramp leading to the polling place and persisted with their falsehoods and high-pressure sales techniques;
  7. attempted to remove rival candidates' how-to-vote pamphlets from voters as they tried to enter the polling place;
  8. set up at polling places the afternoon before polling day, flooding the area with corflutes and bunting promoting the candidate as well as negative messaging on the Albanese Government and the member; and
  9. employed security guards at these polling places to prevent anyone from removing or rearranging this material.

Many of our volunteers felt that the [redacted] volunteers were behaving in an aggressive and threatening manner, not just to rival candidates' volunteers, but to voters as well. As a result, candidates' volunteers and, in some instances, voters raised their concerns about this behaviour with the Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) staff manning the Narooma pre-polling booth and the Tuross Heads, Bodalla, Dalmeny and Narooma polling booths. They were advised that AEC staff were unable to address the concerns raised as it occurred outside the six-metre exclusion zone.

- **potential reform of safety and security arrangements, including consideration of the powers, processes, and capacity of the AEC to manage and address increasingly threatening or disruptive behaviour;**

The Narooma [redacted] Branch would like the AEC empowered and resourced to enforce a candidate volunteer code of conduct that:

1. removes the current first in best dressed approach for where candidate volunteers can set up – this would prevent the flooding of an area by a single candidate thereby restricting the ability of voters to access material from other candidates.
2. set rules for campaign material, including the number of banners and corflutes that can be utilised by a single candidate at pre-poll and polling day booths;
3. completely ban the use of the single-use plastic bunting as it goes directly to landfill and cannot be reused in any capacity; and
4. apply a cap on the number of candidate volunteers to ensure that all candidates have reasonable and proportionate representation at these booths.

It has become clear that the [redacted] engagement of Plymouth Brethren volunteers was a seriously coordinated effort around Australia. This would have required significant financial resources for the transportation, accommodation and payment of Brethren volunteers in New South Wales and Victoria alone. To date, there has been no discloser from the [redacted] or the Plymouth Brethren about why this arrangement was entered into, the cost and what parties expected to receive in return. The Narooma [redacted] Branch believes this arrangement should be investigated by the AEC.

- **the suitability and potential reform of measures to ensure universal voter access, including polling booth availability and location, early voting, remote polling, and postal voting arrangements:**

The Narooma [redacted] Branch is concerned about the inadequacy of the Narooma Country Women's Association (CWA) Rooms at 96 Princes Hwy Narooma NSW 2546 for future pre-polling.

Given the increased population of our part of Eden-Monaro and the massive increase in the number of voters utilising the ability to pre-poll, the Narooma CWA Rooms are manifestly inadequate for pre-polling. The space at the front of the CWA Rooms is narrow – a small, grassed area above a narrow sidewalk that fronts the Princes Highway. This is compounded by there being a single point of entry to the pre-polling booth. This entry point is also the only disabled access to and exit point from the Rooms.

This location also caused significant traffic congestion, not just during peak periods, with a couple of traffic incidents occurring as cars entered and exited at the same point. The Highway is very busy, with large numbers of trucks including semi-trailers going in both directions. All those entering and exiting the Rooms were subjected to significant air and noise pollution from the large semi-trailers passing the site.

The Narooma [redacted] Branch is concerned that these issues make the ongoing use of the Narooma CWA Rooms an Occupational Health and Safety hazard for future AEC employees, voters and volunteers, increasing the risk of injury from falls, traffic accidents and pollution exposure. In this regard we request that another site be found that is more suitable for pre-polling in Narooma, preferably not on the Princes Highway.

- **the suitability of the current authorisation framework and requirements, having regard to the evolution of communication methods and technology.**

  With the evolution of communication methods and technology it is now more important than ever to prevent the deliberate spreading of misinformation. The Narooma [redacted] Branch is of the view that the current authorisation framework and requirements are not keeping pace with the evolution of communication. We believe that priority should be given to introducing truth in political advertising based on the legislation already in place in South Australia and the Australia Capital Territory.

The Special Minister of State has also asked the Committee to consider the interaction with the following:

- the implementation and operation of the electoral reform passed by the 47th Parliament, particularly regarding the use of money or capital in the most recent election;
- reforms to address the ongoing threats of interference in our electoral system, both foreign and domestic; and
- the composition of the Parliament as a whole, including: the length of the parliamentary term; the potential for fixed terms; and the number of elected representatives relative to the growth in population and the electorate.